

investors. The dotcom debacle was still fresh in everybody's minds, and people were sceptical of IPOs in general.

The company announced a floor price of Rs 45, which eventually became its issue price too because of the lukewarm response from investors. At Rs 834 crore, the issue was fairly big for a market still trying to find its feet after the previous year's crash. The overall bearish mood was mainly to blame, and the raw deal that minority shareholders in Bharti Telecom got when that company was delisted in 1999, made some prospective investors wary.

As for me, I had no such qualms. IPOs never excited me, except for the grey market in them. What put me off about IPOs in general was having to buy shares at what the promoter decided was the right price for him. I bought Bharti shares after they listed and kept adding to my positions over the months. Bharti's IPOs were subscribed to around 2.5 times – no mean feat considering the depressed market environment. The decision paid off handsomely a few years later as the mobile phone went on to become an amenity rather than a luxury.

'Many companies will be out of business soon,' I remarked to GB one day as we were discussing the precipitous erosion in stock prices. 'Ah, don't worry about that,' GB said. 'The stock prices may have been hammered, but that does not mean the companies' customers will stop giving them business. The market may think of many of these promoters as shady and most of them actually are. But their products and services are trusted by clients. And that trust is what it takes to stay in business, not a high stock price.'

The market remained lacklustre through 2002 and all the way till May the following year. I was now truly on my own, having split with Monk. He was probed by SEBI because of his dealings with Ketan, and would later be penalized. Since he had routed quite a few of those deals through me, I had SEBI officials landing up at my doorstep too. They could not prove any wrongdoing on my part, but there was still a cost in terms of the time and energy I spent responding to their queries and making repeated trips to their office.

My parting with Monk was amicable, and I returned the money he had loaned me for the BSE membership card. Not long ago, the money would have been loose change for Monk. But the market crash had set him back by a good few crores, and every rupee now mattered.